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CMC, VELLORE, IS BRINGING TOGETHER INTERDISCIPLINARY FIELDS ON A SINGLE PLATFORM CALLED 'NEW MEDICINE'

tion like a marketable commodity," says Dr Surajan Bhattacharji, director, CMC.

But this is the era of cash-rich corporates and singing paeans to the market: look at hospitals as branded products, offer hotel-like facilities, "poach" the best doctors, get the latest technology and make consumers pay through the nose. Will "inner values" work now? "In the post-wto era, we are trying to ensure that our students pick up not just knowledge, skill and attitude," says Dekka, "but also take leadership in healthcare and engage in globally-competitive research." In real terms, that means foraying into new specialisations, research and treatment modalities.

CMC, which occupies the second place, believes in staying ahead of the curve. The Wi-Fi enabled campus and state-of-the-art labs are an icing on a cake rich with specialisation—cardio-thoracic, neuro-sciences, urology, endocrinology, gastroenterology, haematology. "Through interdisciplinary approach, attempts are being made to bring together diverse fields—engineering, zoology, botany, biotech, nutrition—on a single platform called 'new medicine'," explains CMC principal, George Mathew. The college spends Rs 4.8 lakh per annum on a student. AFMC, the third ranker, has invested in training its students in medical simulation for emergencies. It has also set up new centres for bionic ear and anti-retroviral therapy.

Back at AIIMS, just hop on to a battery-operated free parikrama van, weaving a trail around the campus every 15 minutes. And you are sure to bump into a speciality centre at every turn: the towering cardio-neuro centre; the dental research unit near the hostels; India's apex eye referral, R.P. Centre; Institute Rotary Cancer Hospital; the country's first full-fledged trauma unit at Jai Prakash Narayan Trauma Centre; Organ Retrieval Banking Organisation; the Centre for Community Medicine near the old or block. "With 50 departments and superspeciality centres, we are equipped to handle practically all types of diseases," says Y.K. Gupta, head of pharmacology and spokesperson for AIIMS. With it all, the institute spends Rs 31.31 lakh on a undergrad per year per course.

From the Nehruvian vision to liberalisation, from Bhore Committee's (1946) dream of "socially committed" doctors to "brain drain"—it has been a long march for India's medical schools. Caught between the extremes are institutions that believe in "inner values". "India has around 290 medical colleges, but the purpose of the MBBS has not been realised," says Dekka. "The need of the hour is to create a new category of health-care professionals, lower than the MBBS, equipped for preventive and promotive healthcare in rural India." That would free up top colleges from patient overload and allow them to hone their students in cutting-edge research and best clinical practices. A dream that will open up a new chapter for most of the toppers on our list.

with Mahalingam Ponnusamy